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Prompt Anatomy

Use this when: you want an AI assistant to give a useful, checkable answer on the first try.

Works with Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini
Sheet v1.0 · Sep 2026

The 6 parts of a strong prompt

Use the parts you need; order is flexible

EXAMPLE PROMPT · HELP DESK

ROLE	You are a senior network engineer coaching a new help-desk tech.
TASK	Find the likely reason this PC has no internet and give the next 3 checks.
CONTEXT	Wi-Fi shows "connected". Output below: <ipconfig> IPv4 169.254.18.7 ... </ipconfig>
LIMITS	Plain English. Read-only commands only. If unsure, say so.
FORMAT	1) likely cause · 2) three numbered checks with the command · 3) what each result means.
EXAMPLE	ping 192.0.2.1 → reply = gateway reachable.

WHY EACH PART HELPS

- Role** sets expertise, tone and audience
- Task** one clear goal with an action verb
- Context** facts it can't guess; wrap pasted data in tags
- Limits** scope, length, tone, what to avoid
- Format** list, table, JSON, steps: easy to check
- Example** shows the pattern better than rules

CHECK BEFORE YOU SEND

- ☐ One clear task
- ☐ Facts it can't guess
- ☐ Output format
- ☐ No secrets pasted

Before → after

VAGUE

"Why is my Wi-Fi broken?"

SPECIFIC

"Windows 11 laptop, Wi-Fi connected but no websites load since this morning's update. Other devices work. Give 3 checks, easiest first, with the command for each."

Power techniques

Few-shot Give 2-3 varied input → output examples

Think first "Reason step by step, then answer"

Tags Split instructions from data: <logs>...</logs>

Chain Big job → small prompts, one step each

Ask me "Ask up to 3 questions before you start"

Success test Say what a good answer must include

Iterate like an engineer

Draft → **Test** → **Review** → **Refine**

Too generic? Add context: device, OS, error text

Wrong shape? Spell out the format or add an example

Too long? Set a limit: "under 120 words"

Made-up facts? Ask for sources; allow "I don't know"

Role: You are a ...
Task: ...
Context: <data> ... </data>
Limits: ... **Format:** ...

Use AI safely

OWASP LLM Top 10 (2025)

DANGER Never paste passwords, API keys, customer data or real configs into a public AI tool. Mask them: <password> , 192.0.2.x .

CAUTION AI can invent commands and flags. Check them in vendor docs and test in a lab before production.

CAUTION Pasted emails, web pages or logs may hide instructions (**prompt injection**). Tag them as data and ignore orders inside.

- REMEMBER**
- Specific in, specific out: vague prompts get vague answers
 - Long pasted data first, your question last
 - Say what **to do**, not only what to avoid
 - New task? Start a **fresh chat** for clean context